

American Government





About the Course

Students will gain a better understanding of the foundation of American democracy as they learn about the key principles of the Constitution, including the separation of powers, checks and balances, and the responsibilities of each branch of government. There will be a special focus on the Bill of Rights so students understand their rights as citizens and the limits of the government. Supplemental material is provided through articles, videos, and Supreme Court cases. Students will engage with these ideas using their Citizenship notebook.

This topic is included in the following course(s): Citizenship: Grade 7 (U.S.)



Placement & Combining Tips

If 8th-grade students have not taken this course or studied the Constitution, they should consider taking it instead of the 8th-grade option.



Scheduling

GRADE	SCHEDULE INFO.	BOOKS
7	American Government: Grade 7 1 time/week 30 min	Your Rugged Constitution

Sample Weekly View

Day 1	Day 2	Day 3	Day 4	Day 5
Citizenship: Grade 7 (U.S.)				
Ethics: Part 1 Community Read Alouds: Grades 1-12		American Government: Grade 7		Plutarch: Grades 6-8 Current Events: Grades 5-8



Planning & Prep

Permission to print for non-commercial use. See Alveary group use policy to use lessons in a group context.

LINKS: Click text or scan the QR code in the top corner of the lesson plan pages to view online resources associated with the lessons.

Responsibility for previewing all links rests with the teacher. All links were checked at the time of publication; however, websites change frequently and may contain objectionable content. Please report broken links by contacting us through our website.

Citizenship: Grade 7 (U.S.)

☐ Make sure your student sets up a Citizenship Notebook. They will need a 3-ring binder, lined notebook paper, and 5 Tabbed Dividers. You can read more about how to set one up and suggestions for various sections in the document in Quick Links.

☐ As desired, plan for a read aloud time. Suggestions are provided in the Community Read Aloud Quick Link, but local favorites are highly recommended whenever possible.

☐ Make a Calendar of Events for Current Events lessons by drawing a calendar grid in a notebook (or print a blank calendar from the internet).



Books & Resources

For book rationales and purchase options, click the Book List link or scan the QR code below.

∞ [View Book List Details](#)

American Government: Grade 7



Your Rugged Constitution



Supplies

For supply list details and basic supplies helpful to have on hand, click the links or scan the QR code below.

∞ [View Basic Supplies](#)

(No Subject Supplies Assigned)



Quick Links

Related Course Quick Links

- ∞ [Extra Helpings](#)
- ∞ [Community Read Alouds](#)
- ∞ [Setting Up a Citizenship Notebook](#)

Click THIS text
or scan the QR
code for links.



American Government: Grade 7

How To Teach



Prepare

Plutarch: Teachers will find it helpful to preread the entire Life first, and then preread the day's passage before each lesson. Mark any passages that should be omitted due to content. (In Anne White's Plutarch Project books, the recommended source for this course, objectionable content has already been omitted.)

Current Events: Preview the news source for suitability.

Most other citizenship topics don't require additional prep.



Recap

Connect back to the previous lesson. (Optional for Current Events).



Introduce

For news sources, show students how to scan the headlines to get an overview first and then choose a story to read.

For Plutarch or other books: Use a picture, a map, or an engaging question to prepare students to receive the story as relevant. You may talk about one or two unfamiliar words that will be crucial to understanding. It is not necessary to cover all unfamiliar words.



Read

Read the selection assigned or the news story chosen. For rich, dense, or more challenging books such as *Ourselves* and *Plutarch*, it is a good idea to read them aloud. Have students keep an eye out for things to add to their Citizenship Notebook, Book of Centuries, and/or Commonplace book.



Narrate

Have the students narrate orally or in writing.



Discuss

Give students an opportunity to share their thoughts on the story and any connections made. For current events, look up where events occurred on a map and ask questions to help students discern the quality of the piece. (e.g., Are there sources cited? Is there an obvious bias? If so, what do other authors have to say on this subject? Are arguments supported by evidence? Is that evidence credible?) Consider reading an alternative perspective.



Citizenship Notebook

Have students record important ideas in their Citizenship Notebooks.



Term 1

WEEK 1 30m American Government: Grade 7 - Lesson 1

The Declaration of Independence

→ INTRO

What do we celebrate on July 4th each year?

→ VIEW

Watch this informative video about the Declaration of Independence.

∞ Video Link: The Declaration of Independence

→ READ

Now, use the link below to read parts of The Declaration of Independence. You don't need to read the whole thing. Try to read something from every section. Here is some background information about it. This document contains five parts. "The introduction 'declares' why the colonies need to be independent of the British Empire. Next, the Preamble explains views about freedom and self-rule. The First Section of the Body states the abuses of King George III, and the Second Section explains how the Colonists appealed in vain to the king, concluding that the United Colonies have the right to be free from the tyrant." (Painless American Government, p.23).

∞ Document Link: The Declaration of Independence

→ DISCUSS

Find a statement from the Declaration of Independence that you found interesting and discuss it with your teacher.

• EXTRA HELPING

View the home of Thomas Jefferson

∞ Image Link: Monticello on Carter Mountain

• IMPORTANT DATES

Declaration of Independence (1776)

WEEK 2 30m American Government: Grade 7 - Lesson 2

Types of Government

Materials: Your Rugged Constitution & Citizenship Notebook

→ RECAP

What do you remember about the Declaration of Independence?

→ INTRO

What kind of government does the United States have? There are three types of governments: 1. Autocracy- one ruler has absolute control and decision-making power 2. Oligarchy- a small group of landowners, military officers, or wealthy business people control the government institutions. 3. Democracy- The citizens together rule themselves (It comes from two Greek words—demos (the people) and kratos (rule of power). The Constitution establishes a federal democratic republic form of government. That is, we have a union of 50 sovereign States. It is a democracy because people govern themselves. It is representative because people choose elected officials by free and secret ballot. It is a republic because the government derives its power from the people.

→ READ, NARRATE, & DISCUSS

p.1-12

∞ Image Link: Copy of the Constitution in The National Archives

→ VIEW & DISCUSS

Look at the map of the forms of government throughout the world. You may need an atlas to identify the specific countries.

∞ Map Link: Map: Forms of Government

→ CITIZENSHIP NOTEBOOK

Copy down the three branches of government shown on p.12 (illustrations optional). Leave plenty of room under each so you can add more details later.

• See the example in Citizenship Notebook (Quick Links)

• EXTRA HELPING

Watch this video for an explanation of how power is divided among the three branches of government.

∞ Video Link: How Power is Divided

• COMPOSITION

What were some of the issues the new country had to deal with? Why was a new governing document needed?

• IMPORTANT DATES

Signing of the Constitution (1787)



Term 1

WEEK 3 30m American Government: Grade 7 - Lesson 3

Congress, House of Representatives

Materials: Your Rugged Constitution & Citizenship Notebook

→ RECAP

What did you read last time?

→ INTRO

The Constitution has become the world's oldest charter of national government in continuous use. With just 27 amendments (additions), it continues to provide the framework for our country.

→ READ, NARRATE, & DISCUSS

p.13-23

- What do you notice about the differences between the House of Representatives and the Senate?

→ CITIZENSHIP NOTEBOOK

- Go back to the chart you made in Lesson 2 and add more information about Congress from this section, including requirements.
- Using the information from this map link, start another chart that lists the people currently in Congress from your state who hold these government positions.
∞ Map Link: Map of Members of Congress
- See the example in Citizenship Notebook (Quick Links)